

Photograph by RASHI DASH



steam from the Opposition criticism of Azad's war on corruption that had so far hit only the lower rung officials. But the reluctance with which the minister relinquished his position in the party reveals serious rift within the state unit of the party. "Political conspiracy is being hatched against me by my rivals within my party and outside it," says Sayeed.

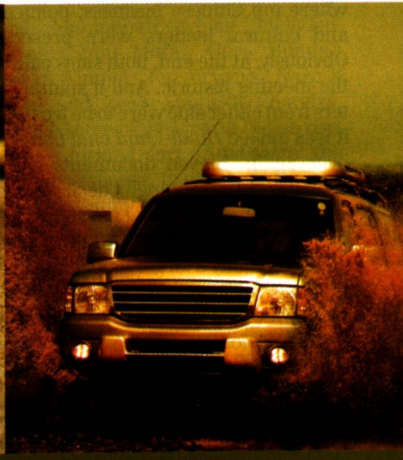
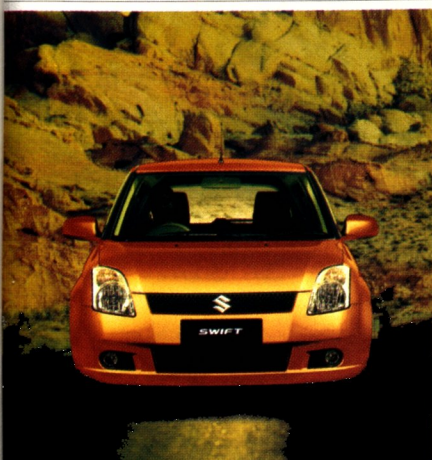
His departure has further reduced the distance between PDP's Deputy Chief Minister Muzaffar Hussain Baig and Azad. Baig's rhetoric about rampant corruption in the state is in unison with the chief minister's pledge to weed out the menace. Given his hot and cold relationship with the PDP leadership, Baig has always found comfort in proximity with Azad. Political speculation is rife with the possibility of Baig actually joining the Congress before the next state elections.

Meanwhile Shoab Lone's zeal raises a question: is he his own man or is he playing someone else's game? During his election campaign the Congress as well as NC had tacitly come to his help when PDP had refused him a party ticket to contest from his slain father's seat.

Inside the Assembly, the young MLA has supported Congress and praised Azad. The estranged PDP bigwig Ghulam Hassan Mir has patronised him all along.

But the timing of his revelation is significant. Public sympathy after his father's assassination contributed to his entry into the legislature. He may be trying to resuscitate the same sentiment to retain his position in the next Assembly. PDP also calls it an "election stunt". Whatever may be Shoab Lone's motivation, the impact may be much wider across the political theatre in the state. Political sources maintain that Lone is actually Mir's man and the latter may soon formally quit PDP along with at least four other legislators of the party to form a 'third front' with other 'likeminded' politicians like M.Y. Tarigami of CPI(M) and Transport Minister Hakim Yaseen.

The Government has assured an all-out effort to find the truth about the corruption charges against a senior minister. But will that inquiry also take note of the fact that one who pays a bribe is also guilty or party to the crime? Shoab Lone must wonder. ■



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